



Overtourism

Can tourism become too successful?

As more people travel than ever before, some beautiful places are paying the price.



Listen to the article

Scan the QR code or visit the link.



Thousands of tourists crowd the streets and beach in Positano, Italy.

WARM-UP

Discuss the questions with a partner.

1. Have you ever visited a place that felt too crowded or too busy? How did it feel?
2. What benefits does tourism bring to a city or a country?

In recent years, the city of Barcelona has seen something strange. Frustrated locals walked through crowded tourist districts carrying water pistols, gently spraying surprised visitors at sidewalk cafés. The playful protest carried a serious message: “Tourists go home.” For a city that welcomes more than 30 million visitors a year, the moment revealed a growing tension between those who live in a place and those who simply pass through.

The problem has a name: overtourism. It happens when a destination attracts more visitors than it can comfortably handle. Cities like Venice, Amsterdam, and Kyoto have all felt the **strain**. A sudden **surge** in arrivals can crowd the streets, push up prices, and slowly change a neighborhood until it no longer feels like home to its **residents**.

The numbers are striking. Venice, a city of fewer than 50,000 residents, can receive up to 100,000 tourists in a single day. Recently it introduced a five-euro entry fee for day-trippers—the first of its kind in the world. Amsterdam has frozen new hotel construction, and even Mount Everest now sees traffic jams of climbers waiting near the summit.

Still, tourism is not the enemy. It creates jobs, supports small businesses, and connects cultures. The real question is balance. Some call for stricter rules to **regulate** visitor numbers; others believe the answer is smarter, more **sustainable** travel. As the backlash grows louder, no easy answer is in sight.

Who really owns a city—the people who live there, or the millions who come to see it?

VOCABULARY

A. Match the words (1–5) with their meanings (A–E).

- | | |
|---------------------|--|
| 1. surge ____ | A. a person who lives in a particular place |
| 2. strain ____ | B. able to continue for a long time without causing harm |
| 3. resident ____ | C. a sudden, large increase |
| 4. regulate ____ | D. pressure caused by too much demand |
| 5. sustainable ____ | E. to control an activity using rules |

TRUE OR FALSE

Read the statements and circle T (True) or F (False).

- | | | |
|---|----------|----------|
| 1. Too many visitors can overwhelm a place. | T | F |
| 2. Venice charges day-trippers a five-euro fee. | T | F |
| 3. The article says tourism is only harmful. | T | F |
| 4. Everest has seen crowds near the summit. | T | F |
| 5. There is one simple solution to overtourism. | T | F |

DISCUSSION

- 1 Have you ever visited a place that felt too crowded? What was it like?
- 2 Has tourism changed a place you know well? How?
- 3 Why might residents and tourists see the same city so differently?
- 4 Do you think entry fees or visitor limits are fair? Why or why not?
- 5 Who do you think a famous city really belongs to—its residents or its visitors?



01 CRITICAL THINKING

YOU ARE THE COUNCIL

Your town has 40,000 residents and three million visitors a year.

Choose the measures you will pass. Every one of them costs somebody something, and you must reach one decision as a council.

MEASURE	WHAT IT FIXES	WHO PAYS FOR IT	PASS
A tourist tax	Raises money to repair the damage crowds cause.	Budget travelers, and the cheap hotels they use.	☐
Cap the cruise ships	Removes the daily surge of thousands at once.	Port workers, guides, and every shop near the harbor.	☐
Ban new hotels	Stops visitor numbers climbing every year.	Construction jobs now, and hotel jobs later.	☐
Rent only to residents	Brings rents down so local families can stay.	Owners who rent short-term — some of them your neighbors.	☐
Timed entry to the old town	Spreads crowds across the day; streets stay walkable.	Anyone who arrives without booking — residents included.	☐
Change nothing	Keeps every job and every euro the visitors bring.	The residents who leave, quietly, one family at a time.	☐

YOUR VOTE Measures passed: _____ of 6 The group you have decided to disappoint: _____

- DISCUSS**
- 1 Would you still vote this way if your own job depended on tourism?
 - 2 Compare with another council. Who protected residents most, and who kept the most jobs?

02 LANGUAGE IN CONTEXT

USE THE LANGUAGE

Complete each sentence with a word from the box. Change the form if you need to.

surge strain residents regulate sustainable

- 1 A sudden _____ in tourists can change a city overnight.
- 2 Too many visitors put a real _____ on local life.
- 3 I think _____ should matter more than tourists.
- 4 Cities should _____ tourism before it gets out of control.
- 5 For me, _____ travel is the only kind worth doing.

04 WRITING

YOUR OPINION

Should popular cities limit the number of tourists they allow?

Write 150–200 words, using ideas and vocabulary from the article.

03 SPEAKING CHALLENGE

ROLE • TASK • PRESENT

In small groups, work through the three steps below.

- | | |
|----------------|---|
| ROLE | You are the local council of a town that has suddenly become a tourist hotspot. |
| TASK | Agree on two rules to manage visitors and protect residents. |
| PRESENT | Share your plan with the class and explain why it is fair to everyone. |